Overall this reads very strong! The only missing link for me is the argument to go from „cute aesthetic" to „sharing / openess". But you can confidently work on the rest of the paper now!

# Cuteness as a Mechanism of Access: The Hyperfeminine Cyberdeck Community as a Case Study in Maker Culture

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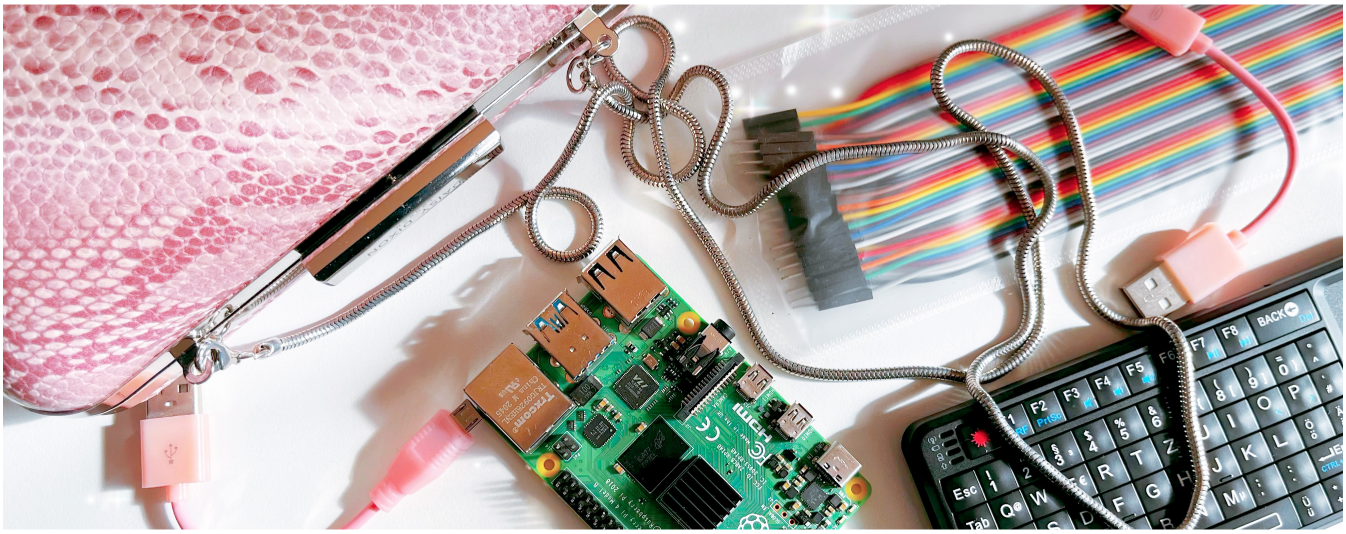

**Figure 1:** *A contemporary hyperfeminine cyberdeck. Image by the author.*

**Abstract**
*Tech culture is becoming increasingly exclusionary and corporatized, making participation in technical spaces feel inaccessible to many. At the same time, a counter-movement is emerging: hyperfeminine creators who are building cyberdecks; custom portable computers with a whimsical and cute aesthetic. These creators share their knowledge openly on social media through tutorials, process documentation, and social media posts. This raises the question of whether cuteness itself can function as a mechanism of access. This paper examines the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community as a case study, drawing on cute studies and maker culture theory to descriptively analyse how aesthetic identity shapes participation in DIY tech spaces. While cuteness and maker culture have each been studied separately, their intersection remains unexplored. This paper offers an initial connection between these two fields, with implications for how we understand inclusion in tech and design culture.*

Overall very good.

+ Here the logic is still a bit weak: you mention „creators share" and the directly jump to „cuteness" — where is the connection? What exactly raises the question?

## 1. Introduction

Do not use the same text in abstract and intro.

There are very strong statements and need either a reference or need to be put more carefully

Big tech companies are currently becoming increasingly exclusionary, technical devices are build as sealed units, so they cannot be easily opened. Tech is becoming simultaneously more corporatized, proprietary, and exclusive. Around the same time some kind of counter-movement is emerging: the hyperfeminine Cyberdeck Community. Women who are building cyber decks and sharing their technical knowledge, whether through documenting the process, through tutorials and workshops, or by simply explaining and showing their results in social media. The cyberdecks and the overall styles of these creators are characterized by a whimsical and cute aesthetic. They do the exact opposite of the big tech corporations: open, repairable, inviting, and made accessible through cuteness.

how so?

How so! That is what you will investigate

If tech culture isolates itself and we fail to understand counter movements that create accessibility to tech, we would miss out on recognizing the mechanisms that invite people into tech spaces.

↳ I would frame this positive: diversify the tech space... it doesn't need the alarming tone.

* introduce what a cyberdeck is

This can be relevant to design, to maker culture and regarding the question of who can contribute to tech in the future.

explain briefly

The whole revived retro-computing trend of „cyberdecks“, from around 40 years ago, was kicked off early this year (2026) primarily by viral videos from Ube Boobey. She had built a small cyberdeck into a chic handbag, with physical computing, and decorated it with accessories such as gold ornaments, plastic plants, and rhinestones. In her first video about that she mentioned that she had no previous experience with tech and that it was her first try. In the following months, more and more creators appeared who built cyberdecks. And they all had something in common: their cyberdecks were kind of cute, aesthetically speaking. ~~This is how I came to the RQ:~~ How does cuteness operate as a mechanism of access in maker culture, and what does the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community illustrate about this?

* find a better transition, as said before

In this paper you will find

what is the difference?

- A descriptive characterization about the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community as phenomenon
- An application of cute studies to the ~~a new context:~~ maker culture/tech context
- An initial connection between two previously separate fields of research: Cute Studies (Dale, 2023) and maker culture/feminist HCI (Bardzell, 2010). Both topics already have been investigated individually but their intersection remains unexplored. The present study aims to fill this gap.

This paper combines academic literature on cute studies with the observation of publicly available social media content from the cyberdeck community, examined through a single descriptive case study and deductive content analysis.

summarize the findings / argument

transition

## 2. Related Work

Dales book "Irresistible" explains why cuteness triggers such strong emotional and psychological responses, and how cute aesthetics have spread globally across culture and design. It is the primary theoretical source for understanding cuteness as a mechanism, directly relevant to the argument that the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community's cute aesthetic characteristics make maker culture emotionally accessible and inviting [Dal]. Bardzell argues that technology design is never neutral. It always encodes assumptions about who the user is. It is relevant because it provides a theoretical framework for understanding why aesthetic choices in tech spaces signal inclusion or exclusion [Bar]. Arulmurugan and Jinnah analyse the key cyberpunk elements in William Gibson's Neuromancer, including hacker culture and the cyberdeck as a tool of digital rebellion [AJ]. The cyberdeck, a term coined by Gibson in that novel, serves as the historical reference point against which the contemporary hyperfeminine cyberdeck revival is contrasted. Shanahan documents, in an magazin article, the current cyberdeck revival as a grassroots response to corporate tech culture. It is relevant as a contemporary source that illustrates the cultural moment in which hyperfeminine cyberdeck communities are emerging [Sha].

## 3. Main Content - Name and Structure the Main Content According to your Paper

Theory: cuteness as mechanism Case Study: describing the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community visual aesthetics of the builds key creators (Ube Boobey as main example and some more) dominant aesthetics: cute, whimsical, color choices knowledge sharing: tutorials, workshops, process documentation Analysis: connecting cuteness theory and maker culture how does cuteness make it accessible to new audiences? what does this reveal about maker culture? "maker culture, the DIY practice of building and modifying physical tech objects"

### 3.1. Method

This paper uses a qualitative, descriptive approach. Academic literature is used here as theoretical framework and publicly available social media content as observational data. It is a single case study and deductive content analysis.

### 3.2. Results

### 3.3. Discussion

Cuteness aesthetic as invitation into tech-spaces. Why now? Bigtech and AI, exclusion as context. Critical questions: community size (is it maybe to nieche?) Researcher bias? Possible Future Work: building a cyberdeck myself, interviews with community members, longitudinal observation (community moves fast). Acknowledgements: documentation of AI use.

good!

## 4. Formatting your paper

### 4.1. Figures

All graphics should be centered.

If your paper includes images, it is important that they are of sufficient resolution to be faithfully reproduced.

Instructions from the original conference template (for the ACS FUB it is not that relevant):

To determine the optimum size (width and height) of an image, measure the image's size as it appears in your document (in millimeters), and then multiply those two values by 12. The resulting values are the optimum $x$ and $y$ resolution, in pixels, of the image. Image quality will suffer if these guidelines are not followed.

Example 1: An image measures 50 mm by 75 mm when placed in a document. This image should have a resolution of no less than 600 pixels by 900 pixels in order to be reproduced faithfully.

This is an examplary reference to Figure 3, which shows the incredible test image from the Eurographics conference.

### 4.2. Tables

A simple table might look like the following. However there are several ways to create and layout tables - it is up to you to style a table up to your liking. This is a reference to Table 1.

**Figure 2:** *Here is a sample figure. All figures must have sensible captions and must be referenced in the text.*

| Col1 | Col2 | Col2 | Col3 |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 6 | 87837 | 787 |
| 2 | 7 | 78 | 5415 |
| 3 | 545 | 778 | 7507 |
| 4 | 545 | 18744 | 7560 |
| 5 | 88 | 788 | 6344 |

**Table 1:** *Here is a sample table. All tables must have sensible captions and must be referenced in the text.*

### 4.3. Formulas

In LaTeX it is fairly easy to add mathematical symbols and formulas. See the following as example [?]:

$$a = bq + r \tag{1}$$

which is true if $a$ and $b$ are integers with $b \neq c$.

$$L' = L\sqrt{1 - \frac{v^2}{c^2}} \tag{2}$$

### 4.4. Footnotes

Please do not use footnotes at all.

### 4.5. References

References are layouted automatically. Add the needed entry to the bibtex file and use the citation command to reference the entry.

If you don't want to mention the author's name just add the citation to the end of the sentence [?]. You can also cite more than one references at the same time [?, ?, ?].

Sometimes you want to refer to the authors name. With this template you need to write out the names manually. For more than two authors you only use the name of the first author and abbrivate the remaining names with "et al."

An example for more than two authors:

Raul et al. [?] thoroughly review the different approaches for segmentation algorithms. Our problem requires the segmentation of color images, summarized by Cheng et al. [?].

An example for two authors:

Also aiming for a fragmented aesthetic appeal by transforming original image data "piecewise", Collomosse and Hall [?] render from salient image features a cubist version of an input. Similarly, Lai and Rosin [?] loosely aim for a cubist appearance by segmenting an input and by simplifying the segments into constant colors, while maintaining global structures.

An example for one author:

Artistically, we are inspired by the art of Wehrli [?], who manually creates image decompositions and rearrangements.

## 5. Conclusion

Summary of key arguments, cuteness as entry mechanism and what this means for maker culture?

## References

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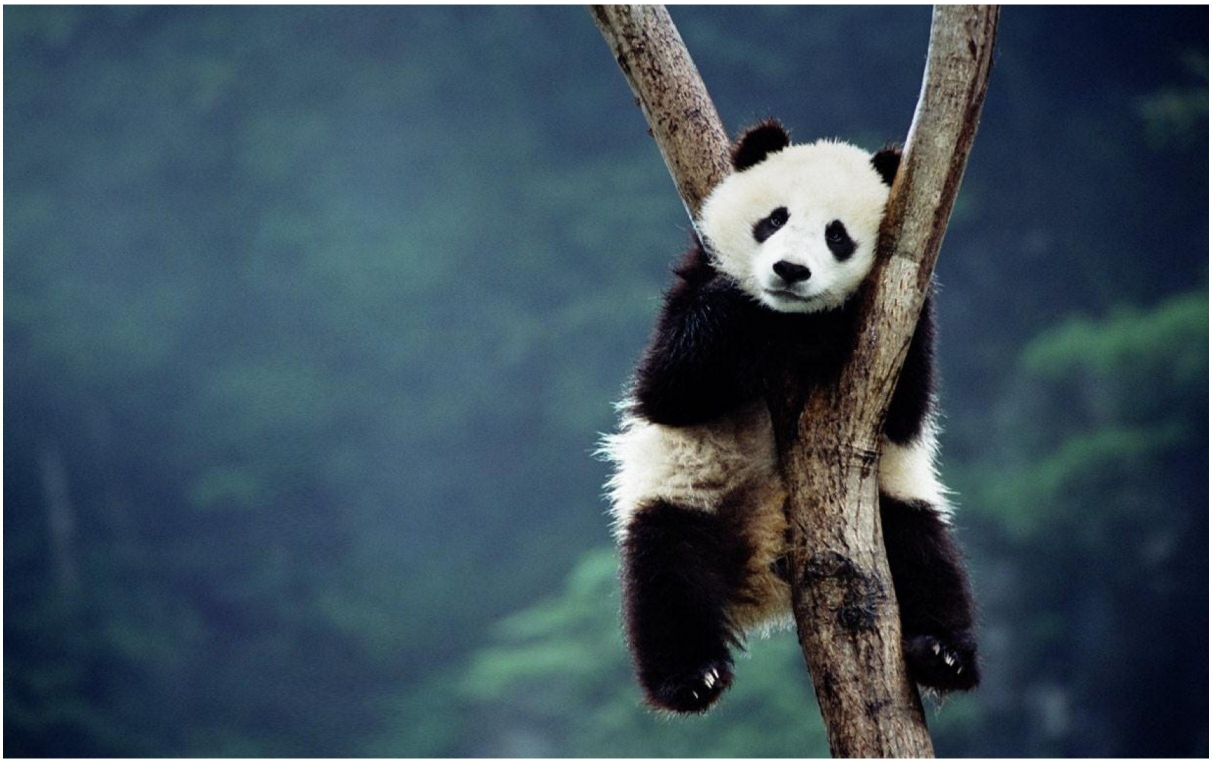

**Figure 3:** *Two-column width figure*